

Related Species *A. malabrica* is used in herbal medicine in Southeast Asia for its tonic properties and to reduce fever.

⚠ **Caution** Use tree of heaven only under professional supervision.

Ajuga reptans (Lamiaceae)

Bugle

Description Low-growing, creeping perennial up to 1 ft (30 cm) in height. Has rooting runners, erect hairy stems, oblong to oval leaves, and purplish-blue flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, North Africa, and parts of Asia, bugle has become naturalized in North America. It prefers damp woods and grassy and mountainous areas, and is usually gathered when in flower in early summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Bugle contains iridoid glycosides, diterpene bitters, phytoecdysone, and caffeic acids.



Bugle was once thought to be a remedy for hangovers.

History & Folklore In the European tradition, bugle has long been valued as a wound-healing herb. Nicholas Culpeper praised it in 1652: "The decoction of the leaves and flowers made in wine and taken, dissolveth the congealed blood in those that are bruised inwardly by a fall or otherwise, and is very effectual for any inward wounds, thrusts or stabs into the body or bowels." The herbalist Mrs. Grieve, writing in 1931, reported that it lowers the pulse rate and "equalizes the circulation."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Bugle is bitter, astringent, and aromatic, but opinion varies as to its value as a medicine. It has mild analgesic properties, and it is still used occasionally as a wound healer. It is also mildly laxative and traditionally has been thought to help cleanse the liver.

Related Species Ground pine (*A. chamaepitys*) is used to treat gout and rheumatism. It is believed to have diuretic, menstruation-inducing, and stimulant properties. *A. decumbens* is used in Chinese medicine as an analgesic.

Albizia lebbek (Fabaceae)

Albizia, Siris Tree, Pit Shirish

Description Deciduous tree growing to 65 ft (20 m). Has compound leaves, white fragrant flowers, and long, shiny, pale yellow seed pods.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Indian subcontinent, albizia grows in moist teak-bearing forests. It is also cultivated.

Parts Used Stem bark; also flowers and seeds.

Constituents Albizzia contains saponins, cardiac glycosides, tannins, and flavonoids.

History & Folklore Albizzia has been used for several thousand years within Ayurvedic medicine to treat allergies, skin eruptions, glandular disorders, and poisoning.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Albizzia bark has anti-allergenic properties and is used orally (and topically) to relieve problems such as eczema, hives, hay fever, and asthma. The herb helps to lower cholesterol and may be useful as part of a broad approach to treating abnormal fat levels in the blood. It is usually taken as a decoction or tincture. In Ayurveda, the bark is given for *pitta* (fire) and *kapha* (water) conditions such as asthma; the flowers for coughs and bronchitis; and the seeds for skin diseases.

Research Laboratory research has shown that the plant helps to reduce allergic sensitivity, and one clinical study has indicated potential value in the treatment of asthma. In another clinical study, weeping eczema improved significantly with

a topical application of albizia. Extracts of the plant also have antifungal and antibacterial activity. Saponins from the seed pods have spermicidal and antiprotozoal activity.

Alchemilla vulgaris (Rosaceae)

Lady's Mantle

Description Herbaceous perennial growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has a basal rosette of lobed leaves and insignificant green flowers 1/8–1/4 in (3–5 mm) across in loose clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Lady's mantle is native to Britain and continental Europe. It is gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Lady's mantle contains tannins, a glycoside, and salicylic acid.



Lady's mantle is chiefly used to reduce heavy menstrual bleeding.

History & Folklore Andres de Laguna's translation (1570) of Dioscorides' *Materia Medica* recommends two preparations of lady's mantle—the root, powdered and mixed with red wine, for internal and external wounds, and an infusion of the aerial parts, for "greenstick" fractures and broken bones in babies and young children. When taken regularly for 15 days, lady's mantle was said to reverse sterility due to "slipperiness" of the womb. The plant's astringent effect is sufficiently marked that the infusion was used to contract the female genitalia, and it was "a thousand times sold" to those wishing to appear to be virgins!

Medicinal Actions & Uses Lady's mantle has always been prized as a wound healer. Its astringency ensures that blood flow is staunch and the first stage of healing soon gets under way. As the name implies, it is a valuable herb for women's complaints and is thought to have a progestogenic action. It is commonly taken to reduce heavy menstrual bleeding, to relieve menstrual cramps, and to aid menstrual regularity. Lady's mantle is also prescribed for fibroids and endometriosis. It has been used to facilitate childbirth, and is thought to act as a liver